**From: Red Clarey, creator of Strottlursia.com**
**I hope you enjoy this piece as much as I did. Knuckles against hinge, elegant in its plainness, refusal to explain; satisfyingly structured. If any of you reading this have questions for Lucas-Reid, he can be messaged via Strottlursia Postal Service. If you wish to take time off to follow your own creative interests, let me know. Life is bigger than productivity and forced meaning. Sometimes we can just do things.**

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# THE HEAVY SHAPES

By L.R. Tavish

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The night started with a houseboat.

He almost missed it — would have, if he hadn't stopped to light a cigarette and had the wind not been coming from the water. The fog had thickened since nine and the street lamps were doing the thing they do in fog, that soft radius of nothing-useful, and he was walking back from somewhere that hadn't been worth going to. Then he stopped, and looked, and there it was.

It was moored at the end of a dock he'd passed a hundred times without registering that the dock led anywhere. The houseboat sat in the water the way something sits when it has given up the pretense of belonging to the world it ended up in. Not derelict — that would have been too easy, too categorizable. It was simply elsewhere. It looked like something that had come from a river system he'd never seen, something carved for water that moved differently than this water moved. The windows were dark but not empty. The whole structure had weight. He stood there for a long time.

He had two tickets in his jacket pocket. He'd put them there that morning without thinking too hard about it, the way you do with things that feel like they'll become relevant later. A concert, he thought, or maybe an exhibition — something that required two people. He couldn't remember who the second ticket had been for. He couldn't remember making the plan. The tickets were expired, he checked, which meant he'd missed whatever it was by at least a day. The paper was soft at the folds from being carried.

He put them back.

The houseboat sat in the water. He watched it until watching it felt like something he was

doing on purpose, and then he walked on.

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The night had started small. That was the thing about this kind of lonely — it didn't announce itself. It arrived as a passing thought around six, something like: there is nowhere I need to be right now. And usually that thought lived in him as a fact and nothing more, something his body understood and filed. But tonight it had opened.

He'd gone out because staying in felt like confirming something he didn't want confirmed. Not unhappiness, exactly. More like the specific weight of an evening that could go anywhere, which sometimes felt identical to an evening that would go nowhere.

He'd gone to the bar on the corner where he knew the bartender by name, and the bartender had been off, and the replacement had been fine, and he'd sat there for forty minutes watching the room fill up with people who were clearly in the middle of something. Not unhappy people. People mid-story. He'd felt like a person between stories, which was not the same as having no story, but felt similar from the inside.

He left and walked.

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The city was doing the thing it does when you're paying attention to it instead of moving through it.

He saw a woman standing very still outside a restaurant, not smoking, not on her phone, just standing. She was wearing something that looked like it belonged to a different decade, not vintage, just — from somewhere else. Like the houseboat. He kept walking but she stayed in him.

He saw two men having an argument that wasn't going to end the way either of them wanted. He knew this because of the angle of their bodies, the way they were both leaning away while speaking forward. The argument was structural, not emotional. They were arguing about something that could be resolved but they had arranged themselves so that the resolution would require one of them to cross a distance the other one had established. He watched them for a moment from across the street. Neither looked up.

He saw a dog sitting in a doorway that it clearly did not live in, and the dog was sitting there with the particular patience of something that knew it was in the wrong doorway but had made a decision. The dog looked at him. He looked at the dog. Some acknowledgment passed between them that didn't require anything further.

He kept walking.

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The heavy shapes were not always ugly. That had surprised him the first time he'd noticed them — that there was a kind of beauty that only existed at a certain weight, that lightness didn't have access to. The houseboat was beautiful. The woman outside the restaurant was beautiful. The dog in the wrong doorway had been, in its way, beautiful.

He thought about this as he walked. He turned it over.

He had a friend — had, past tense now, the friendship had dissolved in the way that friendships dissolve when neither person does anything wrong, just gradually applies their attention elsewhere until the connection becomes a weight neither wants to carry or put down — who had once told him that he had a gift for seeing things that didn't want to be seen. He hadn't known what to do with that at the time. He still didn't, exactly. But walking through the fog with the expired tickets in his pocket he thought maybe his friend had meant something like this: the heavy shapes. The things that were present without advertising themselves.

He wondered if that was a gift. He wondered if it was something else.

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Around eleven he found himself at a small park he hadn't intended to walk to. There was a bench. He sat on it.

The fog was very thick now. He could hear the water somewhere nearby but couldn't see it. A light somewhere to his left made a circle on the ground that didn't reach anything. He sat in it anyway.

He took the tickets out of his pocket and looked at them.

He still couldn't remember. The plan, the person, the occasion. He remembered putting the tickets in his pocket and feeling like he was being organized, being a person who had plans and honored them. He remembered, distantly, the pleasure of having somewhere to be with someone. But the someone had gone the way the bartender had gone — replaced by a fact of absence that was not unkind, just present.

He thought: I must have meant to meet someone.

He thought: I wonder what we would have seen.

He held the tickets for a while. Not with grief — that would have been too big for what this was. With something smaller. The size of a passing thought at six o'clock that had grown into an evening through no particular intention of its own.

He put the tickets back.

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On the way home he passed the houseboat again.

The fog had done something to it in the hour since he'd first seen it. It was more itself now, or more elsewhere — he couldn't tell which. It sat in the water with the same particular quality of having arrived from a different place and not quite reconciled itself to this one.

He stood there again for a long time.

He thought about the woman outside the restaurant, the two men and their structural argument, the dog in the wrong doorway. He thought about the tickets. He thought about his friend who had said he had a gift for seeing things that didn't want to be seen, and he thought about how that friend was someone who was gone now without anything so clean as a reason.

He thought: the heavy shapes are not always ugly.

He thought: sometimes they are just true.

He walked home. The fog was very thick. His feet knew the way.

Inside, he put the tickets on the counter. He thought he might keep them, or he thought he might throw them away in the morning when they felt like less. He wasn't sure which he would do and didn't decide.

He brushed his teeth.

He stood for a moment in front of the bathroom mirror.

The face that looked back at him was ordinary and his. He stayed with it long enough to find the thing underneath the ordinary — the part that had been out walking all night in the fog, had stopped for the houseboat, had watched the dog in the wrong doorway, had carried the expired tickets in his pocket for a person whose name had slipped away from him without his permission.

That part was still there. Untouched.

He turned off the light.

He slept.

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In the morning the tickets were still on the counter.

He left them there.